Service Statement

I first discovered the world of academic service by sitting in on the "Business Meeting" at NAACL 2018 [1], the first conference I presented at. The program chairs of the conference presented a large number of dizzying stats: how many reviewers and chairs were required, what updates were made to the conference and review process, how much funding was obtained, how much was used, and what decisions needed to be made behind the scenes. I remember thinking that this was fascinating[1] and couldn't wait to be involved. I was told by countless senior collaborators that reviewing and chairing would very quickly get very tedious, but I was undeterred. Shortly after, as a PhD student, I started to review for any NLP and ML conferences that I was eligible for, and I now regularly serve as either Area Chair or Senior Area Chair for select conferences. I still find the process both interesting and intellectually fulfilling. I view academic service as an integral part of the research process, and I'm excited to continue contributing to the research communities I am a part of. I'm also excited to extend this service to more academic settings in the form of departmental or university service and more public-facing outreach programs. My previous experiences with academic service, as well as future goals are described in the sections below.

Chairing & Reviewing

I have served in leadership roles for major conferences in NLP and machine learning, including as a **Senior Area Chair** for NAACL 2025, EMNLP 2024 and ICLR 2024, and as an **Area Chair** for COLM, NeurIPS, ACL, EMNLP, NAACL, FaccT, and ICLR over multiple years. I also review for select **conferences** such as CHI, FaccT, ICML, RSS etc., as part of paper submission requirements. When invited, I also regularly review for **journals** such as Computational Linguistics, Transactions of the Association for Computational Linguistics, Transactions on Machine Learning Research, and the Journal of Machine Learning Research. Taking on these roles over the years has given me great clarity, as well as appreciation, for the challenges of evaluating research fairly and efficiently in rapidly evolving fields. I plan to continue chairing the conferences I regularly publish it; and I'm also excited to review and engage with more **interdisciplinary conferences**, journals and forums that I've been invited to be a part of. Lastly, the recent challenges of AI-generated papers; as well as the overloaded review schedules and burdens placed on researchers, has resulted in many forward-looking ideation sessions and conversations that I have had with prominent researchers in my field. I'm excited to help brainstorm, initiate and **support new venues** and forums that overcome some of these challenges and help the research communities still function effectively.

Tutorials & Lectures

I'm excited about discovering creative ways to help people understand the complex, and rapidly evolving research methods to large and cross-disciplinary audiences. At ACL 2021, I co-organized a **tutorial on language models and multimodal inputs** that was attended by more than 1000 virtual attendees [2]. Given the interdisciplinary nature of this research topic, the audience involved people from various backgrounds spanning computer vision, natural language, machine learning; as well as some with no background in any of the above. At DeepMind, in 2022, I organized an internal week-long **language model training tutorial** for the multi-agent team: to researchers with deep expertise in game theory, optimization and multi-agent reinforcement learning; but none, in linguistics, transformer architectures or language modeling. These tutorials required a significant amount of complex material that needed to be delivered to I have also delivered lectures at prominent **summer schools** (M2L 2022 and M2L 2024); **guest lectures** at Brown University (CS 1460 taught by Ellie Pavlick), UC Berkeley (CS 294-320 taught by Anca Dragan), **seminars** at Pomona University, the DIMACs institute, McGill University, Princeton University and others. I also regularly give **invited talks** at workshops; and also partake in **advisory boards** for students organizing workshops directly related to my research interests.

[1] It is worth noting that I was only an undergraduate, and had not yet started to even review for this conference. Part of the appeal was my being newly introduced to the world of research, and my unawareness of what academic service tasks entailed. That said, I do find all the service tasks I do intellectually fulfilling; and I still try to sit in on business meetings when I have the time, at least for the NLP conferences!

Outreach & Inclusion

I'm excited to engage with diversity and outreach programs: I strongly believe that research communities benefit from the perspectives that diversity and interdisciplinary collaboration bring. The summer schools I lectured at had large components of students funded through **diversity initiatives**, which brought so many novel perspectives to the classes I taught. I am eager to incorporate such initiatives into future recruitment and organizational capacities I take on. I also regularly partake in committees such as WiML (Women in Machine Learning), WiNLP, EquiCL, Birds-of-a-Feather, and other diversity and inclusion groups I am invited to advise on. Moreover, a large component of the summer course that I taught at Brown, was to involve students that are underrepresented and have non-traditional computer science backgrounds, to engage with research in machine learning. Seeing the range of applicants to such programs, as well as the outcomes in terms of high quality research that could be produced was eye-opening to me. Moreover, during the summer of 2020, together with a group of PhD students we organized a reading group on topics of fairness, equality and safety in machine learning research. We thoroughly reviewed best practices in ethics fields and existing implementations, and used this to help design Brown Computer Science's first Ethics and AI course.

Lab & Seminar Organization

During my PhD, I helped organize the "Super Lab" seminar series: **a cross-lab initiative** to allow students to present research to the department on a bi-weekly basis. This was attended by up to 30 students and faculty across labs and departments such as computer science, cognitive science, linguistics and psychology. I was also involved in graduate student **community efforts to mentor** first-year PhD students and provide a source of informal guidance, experience, and support during the PhD. As a more senior PhD student, I was also involved in **recruitment** for my lab, as well as asked to sit in on faculty job talks to provide student perspectives on incoming faculty. On joining DeepMind, I was involved in similar recruitment and hiring decisions for my team at a much larger scale; and also took advantage of Google's mentorship program, to mentor engineers and researchers at various stages of their careers. By the end of three years, I had mentored 11 employees in total. I was also responsible for 7 speakers that we hosted at DeepMind, two reading groups across more than 10 teams in the company, and 6 PhD student research interns.

Future Service

Many years from my first introduction to academic research, I continue to be excited about academic service. As a faculty member, I'm very much looking forward to contributing to the intellectual life of the department: through standard **admission, recruitment and workshop committees**; as well as new and creative ways to foster intellectual spirit in this new and rapidly evolving technological world. I'm excited to lead **events that span disciplines**: my lab will have reading groups, seminars, and collaborative events that engage with necessary social science and humanities fields, as well as tech and policy researchers. I also hope to contribute to the development of responsible research practices within academic AI laboratories, particularly around evaluation rigor, research transparency, and mentoring. Ultimately, I view service not as separate from research and teaching, but as part of the infrastructure that makes both possible. I look forward to continuing my contributions to the NLP and machine learning communities while taking on the new responsibilities of departmental and university service as a faculty member.

References

[1] Marilyn Walker, Heng Ji, and Amanda Stent, editors. *Proceedings of the 2018 Conference of the North American Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics: Human Language Technologies, Volume 2 (Short Papers)*, New Orleans, Louisiana, June 2018. Association for Computational Linguistics.

[2] Afsaneh Hajiamin Shirazi, Arjun Gopalan, Arsha Nagrani, Blaž Bratanič, Cesar Ilharco Magalhaes, Christina Liu, Felipe Ferreira, Gabriel Fedrigo Barcik, Georg Fritz Osang, Jared Frank, and Roma Patel. Recognizing multimodal entailment. *ACL Tutorial*, 2021.